

The Morning Briefing

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US POLITICS · JUDICIARY · ISRAEL & MIDEAST · VATICAN · WORLD · RESEARCH

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LEAD STORY — JUDICIARY

Justices weigh whether Trump can seize control of mail voting before the midterms

States ask the Supreme Court to keep a lower-court block on the president's mail-ballot executive order in place, setting up the year's marquee separation-of-powers fight over who actually runs American elections.

US POLITICS

Blanche clears Judiciary Committee 12-10 as Collins breaks ranks

The Senate Judiciary Committee advanced Todd Blanche's nomination for attorney general on a straight party-line 12-10 vote Tuesday, sending it to the floor with Republican leaders hoping to confirm him before the August recess. The panel's holdout Republicans, Sens. John Cornyn and Thom Tillis, agreed to release their votes after Blanche put in writing that the White House's controversial "anti-weaponization fund" is dead.

WHY IT MATTERS

Blanche is Trump's own former defense lawyer being installed atop the Justice Department. The weaponization-fund fight was the last real point of Republican friction, and it has now evaporated — but Sen. Susan Collins says she will vote no on the floor, and Sen. Lisa Murkowski remains undecided, which means the confirmation is not yet a lock.

NPR — [npr.org/2026/08/03/g-s1-136864/todd-blanche-rescinds-trump-anti-weaponization-fund](https://www.npr.org/2026/08/03/g-s1-136864/todd-blanche-rescinds-trump-anti-weaponization-fund)

Twenty-five states sue over new tariffs, call forced-labor rationale a "pretext"

A coalition of 25 Democratic-led states, led by California, filed suit Monday against new Section 301 tariffs of 10 to 12.5 percent on more than 80 countries, imposed July 23 on

stated forced-labor grounds. California Attorney General Rob Bonta called it "President Trump's third attempt to illegally impose tariffs," after the Supreme Court ruled in February that IEEPA does not authorize this kind of levy.

WHY IT MATTERS

This is a direct test of whether the administration can route around a Supreme Court loss simply by re-issuing the same tariffs under a different statute.

Al Jazeera — [aljazeera.com/news/2026/8/4/trump-administration-sued-by-25-states-under-trumps-new-tariffs-on-trading-partners](https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2026/8/4/trump-administration-sued-by-25-states-under-trumps-new-tariffs-on-trading-partners)

Bishop Barber arrested at Capitol protest fusing Iran and voting-rights fights

Religious leaders and activists, including Bishop William J. Barber II of Repairers of the Breach, were arrested Monday at the Capitol while protesting both the strikes on Iran and the administration's mail-in voting order.

WHY IT MATTERS

The Iran and voting-rights fights are now being fused into a single protest movement — a sign of how connected the White House's foreign and domestic power plays look to its critics.

Democracy Now! — [democracynow.org/2026/8/4/headlines](https://www.democracynow.org/2026/8/4/headlines)

JUDICIARY & SCOTUS

States fight to keep mail-voting order blocked as appeals courts split

States are asking the Supreme Court to leave in place a lower-court injunction against Trump's mail-in voting executive order, which directs the Postal Service to obtain state voter lists and stop delivering ballots to anyone not on them. Twenty-three mostly Democratic-led states and Washington, DC already won that injunction; the administration wants the Court to lift it nationwide before the midterms, and two federal appeals panels have reached opposite conclusions on the underlying question.

ANALYTICAL READ

The Constitution's Elections Clause gives election administration to the states and to Congress, not the president — the executive is not mentioned in Article I, Section 4 at all. This is the marquee separation-of-powers fight of the year, and the outcome could determine what mail voting actually looks like in November.

SCOTUSblog — [scotusblog.com/2026/08/states-challenging-executive-order-on-mail-in-voting-ask-justices-to-leave-in-place-limits-on-it](https://www.scotusblog.com/2026/08/states-challenging-executive-order-on-mail-in-voting-ask-justices-to-leave-in-place-limits-on-it)

Court sets October calendar: climate change and immigration detention headline the term

The Supreme Court announced Tuesday the cases it will hear in October, including significant disputes over climate change liability and immigration detention authority.

WHY IT MATTERS

This sets the frame for the entire term — both issues sit squarely at the intersection of executive power and the federal courts' willingness to check it.

SCOTUSblog — scotusblog.com/2026/08/court-announces-cases-it-will-hear-in-october-which-include-significant-disputes-on-climate-change-and-immigration-detention/

Trump personally petitions Court over \$83.3 million defamation verdict

Trump has asked the Supreme Court to hear his appeal of an \$83.3 million defamation verdict entered against him.

WHY IT MATTERS

It is unusual for a sitting president to be personally petitioning the Court in a private civil matter at the same moment his administration has multiple separation-of-powers cases pending before the same nine justices.

SCOTUSblog — scotusblog.com/2026/07/trump-asks-supreme-court-to-hear-appeal-of-83-million-defamation-verdict-against-him/

ISRAEL & THE MIDDLE EAST

Netanyahu rejects Gaza withdrawal plan; Bennett accuses him of stalling for votes

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu rejected the Board of Peace's Gaza withdrawal plan and a competing White House draft this week, saying Israel will not pull back "from our current lines" until Hamas is "completely disarmed." Former Prime Minister Naftali Bennett countered that Hamas had already accepted the plan and accused Netanyahu of using an uptick in strikes to "derail the plan's implementation and block peaceful solutions."

ANALYTICAL READ

Israel's own current lines already extend well past the October 2025 ceasefire boundary — from roughly 53 percent of Gaza to over 60 percent — so "disarmament first" functions less as a security precondition than as cover for holding newly seized ground. Netanyahu is speaking to Israeli voters 84 days before a general election, not to Washington; the gap between what the White House wants (a completed withdrawal) and what his government has an incentive to deliver (continued presence, a tougher public posture) is a textbook US-Israel divergence of interest, not a shared read of the security picture.

The Times of Israel — timesofisrael.com/liveblog-august-4-2026/

All Gaza strikes now require IDF chief's personal sign-off

The IDF has tightened internal rules so that every strike in Gaza now requires approval from Chief of Staff Eyal Zamir, following strikes over the weekend that killed multiple people the military described as terrorists from several armed factions.

ANALYTICAL READ

Centralizing sign-off this explicitly, in the middle of a contested ceasefire, suggests the military leadership is worried about strikes running ahead of political control at a moment of intense international scrutiny. Worth watching whether that discipline holds if Netanyahu keeps rejecting withdrawal terms.

The Jerusalem Post — jpost.com/israel-news/defense-news/article-904571

US and Iran near Hormuz deal; Israel goes quiet in public

The United States and Iran are working through Oman toward reopening the Strait of Hormuz, with Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent suggesting a deal to stabilize energy prices could land by August 5. The 60-day window set by the underlying nuclear memorandum of understanding has fewer than 30 days left to run.

ANALYTICAL READ

Washington's incentive here is de-escalation and cheaper oil; Israel's incentive is maximum, continuing pressure on Iran's nuclear program. Israeli officials have stayed publicly silent on Iran exactly as the US pushes for a deal, while reportedly pressing privately for more "kinetic and non-kinetic" measures — that silence is itself a data point, not an absence of one, and it is worth treating any anonymously sourced Israeli position on Iran that surfaces in Hebrew media in the coming days as positioning rather than neutral assessment.

CNN — cnn.com/2026/08/04/world/live-news/iran-war-trump/

Protesters storm toward Religious Zionist HQ as poll shows 62% doubt "total victory"

Left-wing protesters attempted to force their way into Religious Zionist party headquarters in Jerusalem on August 5, part of a broader run of politically charged unrest that also includes a new poll finding 62 percent of Israelis doubt Netanyahu's promised "total victory" will ever arrive, as the country heads toward a general election at the end of October.

WHY IT MATTERS

Domestic political fracture is now running in parallel with the Gaza and Iran fights, and all of it is being read by the Israeli public through the lens of an imminent election rather than settled policy.

The Jerusalem Post — jpost.com/israel-news/politics-and-diplomacy/article-904636

ITALY, ROME & THE VATICAN

Pope Leo to spend eleven days in Uruguay, Argentina and Peru this November

The Holy See Press Office announced that Pope Leo XIV will make an Apostolic Journey to Uruguay, Argentina, and Peru from November 6 to 17 — his sixth international trip. He will visit Montevideo, Paysandu, and Florida in Uruguay; Buenos Aires, Cordoba, and Lujan in Argentina; and Lima, Chiclayo, Cusco, and Pucallpa in Peru. Uruguay has the lowest share of Catholics of any country in Latin America, at 36 percent. Argentina was the homeland of Pope Francis, who never managed to visit as pope across twelve years. Peru is where Leo himself served for years as a missionary and bishop and holds citizenship.

WHY IT MATTERS

This is Leo choosing the region he knows best, and the one Francis conspicuously never visited — a strong early signal of where he intends to invest his papacy's attention.

Vatican News — vaticannews.va/en/pope/news/2026-08/pope-to-make-apostolic-journey-to-uruguay-argentina-and-peru.html

Pope to Knights of Columbus: be "prophets of harmony" in a divided age

In a video message to the Knights of Columbus' 144th Supreme Convention in Denver on August 4, Pope Leo urged the Order to become "prophets of harmony" under the gathering's theme, "In The One, We Are One." "The preservation of unity is often not easy, and it cannot be taken for granted," he said. "It must be actively cultivated through honest and humble dialogue." He continued: "In an

age all too often marked by division and pointed rhetoric, there is a great need for prophets of harmony who seek to build bridges and strive to reconcile opposing positions wherever possible." The Pope praised the Order's work on behalf of "the unborn, expectant mothers, persecuted Christians, victims of war and human trafficking," tracing its mission to founder Blessed Michael McGivney.

WHY IT MATTERS

This is Leo's clearest public statement yet on internal Church and civic polarization, delivered directly to the largest lay Catholic fraternal organization in the United States.

Vatican News — vaticannews.va/en/pope/news/2026-08/pope-leo-videomessage-knights-of-columbus-144-supreme-convention.html

Pope mourns Mozambican cardinal who "proclaimed peace"

Pope Leo sent a telegram mourning the death of Mozambican Cardinal Dom Julio Duarte Langa, praising him as a churchman who "proclaimed peace."

Vatican News — vaticannews.va/en/pope/news/2026-08/pope-sends-telegram-for-death-of-cardinal-who-proclaimed-peace.html

At Angelus, Pope flags "alarming situation" at Spain's Ceuta border

At Sunday's Angelus, Pope Leo said he was following "with concern the alarming situation in Ceuta," the Spanish enclave in North Africa currently facing a migrant surge.

Vatican News — vaticannews.va/en/pope/news/2026-08/pope-leo-xiv-impassioned-appeal-sunday-angelus-2-august-2026.html

WORLD NEWS

Migrant surge builds at Ceuta, Spain's North African foothold

The Pope's Ceuta remarks point to a fast-building migration crisis on Spain's North African border, where Ceuta's small land frontier with Morocco has again become a flashpoint.

WHY IT MATTERS

This is the kind of story that tends to surface first in papal remarks before it reaches the wider English-language press.

Vatican News — vaticannews.va/en/pope/news/2026-08/pope-leo-xiv-impassioned-appeal-sunday-angelus-2-august-2026.html

October 7 film selected for Toronto festival despite boycott push

An Israeli film about October 7 was selected for the Toronto International Film Festival despite an unofficial industry boycott of Israeli cinema.

WHY IT MATTERS

A small data point, but a real one, on whether cultural isolation of Israel is hardening or starting to crack at major Western institutions.

The Jerusalem Post — jpost.com/israel-news/culture/article-904569

RESEARCH & LONG READS

"States, Not the President, Run Elections in America"

Jess Brouard & Derek Tisler — *State Court Report* (Brennan Center for Justice)

A clear walkthrough of the Elections Clause: Article I, Section 4 gives states the power to set the times, places, and manner of federal elections, with Congress able to make or alter those rules. The executive branch appears nowhere in that grant of authority. Directly on point for today's mail-in voting fight at the Supreme Court, and worth reading before that case is decided, not after.

State Court Report — statecourtreport.org/our-work/analysis-opinion/states-not-president-run-elections-america

"The Peculiarity of Papal Primacy"

Fr. Olek Stirrat — *Catholic World Report*

An apologetic case for papal primacy grounded in the Davidic-kingdom typology behind Matthew 16, then built out through Vatican I's Pastor Aeternus and Joseph Ratzinger's seven limits on papal power, arguing the papacy functions more like a constitutional monarchy than an absolute one. A useful companion to today's Knights of Columbus story: it explains the doctrinal basis for the Pope's own authority to speak "prophetically" to the Order in the first place.

Catholic World Report — catholicworldreport.com/2025/01/29/the-peculiarity-of-papal-primacy